

SOLVED PRACTICE WORKBOOK

Central Asian Contacts: Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Kushanas - Learner-v2 Refreshed

UPSC complete learning session | Foundation to advanced | Concepts, evidence, practice and answer writing

Central Asian Contacts: Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Kushanas	
01. SCOPE: CONNECTED FRONTIER WORLDS, NOT ONE FOREIGN WAVE Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Parthians and Kushanas must be separated by	02. ROUTES AND POLITICAL MOVEMENT: GEOGRAPHY AS OPPORTUNITY AND Manuscript use the a route map plus a geography qualification
03. SOURCE MATRIX: HOW THE PERIOD IS RECONSTRUCTED Technically, Source matrix: how the period is reconstructed is	04. CHRONOLOGY FIREWALL: RANGES, OVERLAP AND DEBATED ISSUES Technically, Chronology: forward ranges, overlap and debated end is
05. INDO-GREEK FORMATION, GEOGRAPHY AND POLITICAL PLURALITY In general terms is divided into two but rather than a unified Indian	06. READING INDO-GREEK COINS: INNOVATION, AUTHORITY AND LIMITS For use only: a historical formulation regarding coins: extensive
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Original deterministic study visual; labels are explanatory, not textual quotations.

Source order: repository knowledge -> official current linkage -> clearly marked analysis. No fabricated PYQs or statistics.

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Central Asian Contacts: Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Pahlavas and Kushanas - Complete Topic Package

BASIC MCQS / REMEDIATION

Hard MCQ 01

Question: Which sequence best preserves group distinctions?

- (A) Indo-Greek -> Shaka -> Pahlava -> Kushana, with regional overlap
- (B) Greek -> Kushana -> Maurya -> Shaka
- (C) Shaka and Pahlava as one dynasty
- (D) All four as branches of the Yuezhi

Answer: A - Indo-Greek -> Shaka -> Pahlava -> Kushana, with regional overlap Named evidence/concept: Terminology and overlap.

Explanation: Prevents collapse of separate polities. **Qualification:** Sequence is broad, not universal in every region.

Hard MCQ 02

Question: Which source is most decisive for attributable Indo-Greek rulers?

- (A) Ashokan pillar edicts
- (B) Portrait coins with royal names and bilingual legends
- (C) Sangam poems
- (D) Puranic king lists alone

Answer: B - Portrait coins with royal names and bilingual legends Named evidence/concept: Indo-Greek coinage.

Explanation: Names rulers and political communication. **Qualification:** Distribution is not an exact frontier.

Hard MCQ 03

Question: Demetrius is important because he is associated with:

- (A) The Junagadh repair
- (B) Founding the Shaka era
- (C) An early Bactrian Greek crossing south of the Hindu Kush
- (D) Unifying the Great Yuezhi

Answer: C - An early Bactrian Greek crossing south of the Hindu Kush Named evidence/concept: Demetrius coin sequence.

Explanation: Marks Indo-Greek formation. **Qualification:** Campaign extent is reconstructed.

Hard MCQ 04

Question: The safest reading of Menander is:

- (A) A Kardamaka satrap
- (B) The author of Milindapanho
- (C) A Kushana founder
- (D) A coin-rich Indo-Greek ruler remembered as Milinda in Buddhist dialogue literature

Answer: D - A coin-rich Indo-Greek ruler remembered as Milinda in Buddhist dialogue literature Named evidence/concept: Coins plus Milindapanho.

Explanation: Combines political and intellectual evidence. **Qualification:** Dialogue is not a transcript.

Hard MCQ 05

Question: Milindapanho is best classified as:

- (A) Dialogic Buddhist literature with historical value and genre limits
- (B) A coin catalogue
- (C) A Greek embassy report
- (D) An official court diary

Answer: A - Dialogic Buddhist literature with historical value and genre limits Named evidence/concept: Milinda-Nagasena dialogue.

Explanation: Illuminates Buddhist reasoning. **Qualification:** Composite literary history.

Hard MCQ 06

Question: The Heliodorus pillar directly records:

- (A) Menander founding a monastery
- (B) An ambassador of Antialcidas dedicating a garuda pillar to Vasudeva
- (C) Rudradaman repairing a lake
- (D) Kanishka founding an era

Answer: B - An ambassador of Antialcidas dedicating a garuda pillar to Vasudeva Named evidence/concept: Besnagar inscription.

Explanation: Diplomacy and Bhagavata affiliation. **Qualification:** One individual is not a population.

Hard MCQ 07

Question: Agathocles' coin series is significant for:

- (A) Kushana divine kingship
- (B) The first Junagadh Sanskrit prashasti
- (C) Early datable Balarama-Vasudeva imagery with bilingual legends
- (D) A Sasanian conquest

Answer: C - Early datable Balarama-Vasudeva imagery with bilingual legends Named evidence/concept: Agathocles coins.

Explanation: Royal recognition of Indian cults. **Qualification:** Does not prove private conversion.

Hard MCQ 08

Question: Which statement about Indo-Greek chronology is strongest?

- (A) Indo-Greek rule ended everywhere simultaneously
- (B) One unified dynasty ruled all north India
- (C) Every ruler has exact literary dates
- (D) Several rulers and lines were concurrent and remain coin-reconstructed

Answer: D - Several rulers and lines were concurrent and remain coin-reconstructed Named evidence/concept: Numismatic sequence.

Explanation: Explains overlap. **Qualification:** Chronology remains revisable.

Hard MCQ 09

Question: Maues/Moga is associated with:

- (A) Early Shaka authority in the Taxila-Gandhara region
- (B) Gupta Udayagiri
- (C) Mauryan Pataliputra
- (D) Kushana Mathura sculpture

Answer: A - Early Shaka authority in the Taxila-Gandhara region Named evidence/concept: Taxila inscription and coins.

Explanation: Anchors a Shaka line. **Qualification:** Conquest sequence remains debated.

Hard MCQ 10

Question: Rajuvula is best linked to:

- (A) The Kshaharata line at Nashik
- (B) The Mathura Shaka branch and the capture of Sagala
- (C) The Yuezhi migration in Gansu
- (D) The Besnagar embassy

Answer: B - The Mathura Shaka branch and the capture of Sagala Named evidence/concept: Shaka sequence.

Explanation: Shows regional replacement of Indo-Greeks. **Qualification:** Not all-India rule.

Hard MCQ 11

Question: The kshatrapa system should be understood as:

- (A) A monastic hierarchy
- (B) A fixed Mauryan copied constitution
- (C) Delegated regional rule that could generate autonomy
- (D) A Roman municipal office

Answer: C - Delegated regional rule that could generate autonomy Named evidence/concept: Titles and branch histories.

Explanation: Explains expansion and fragmentation. **Qualification:** Functions varied.

Hard MCQ 12

Question: Which distinction is correct?

- (A) Nahapana was Kushana
- (B) Rudradaman was Indo-Greek
- (C) All three were Pahlavas
- (D) Nahapana was Kshaharata; Chashtana and Rudradaman were Kardamaka

Answer: D - Nahapana was Kshaharata; Chashtana and Rudradaman were Kardamaka Named evidence/concept: Western Kshatrapa lines.

Explanation: Prevents dynastic mixing. **Qualification:** Dates still need inscription/coin checks.

Hard MCQ 13

Question: Ushavadata's records are especially useful for:

- (A) Donations, routes and Nahapana's southern political network
- (B) Yuezhi migration
- (C) Menander's ashes
- (D) Kanishka's Bactrian genealogy

Answer: A - Donations, routes and Nahapana's southern political network Named evidence/concept: Nashik and Karle inscriptions.

Explanation: Connects patronage and region. **Qualification:** Not a fiscal census.

Hard MCQ 14

Question: Nahapana's defeat is strongly supported by:

- (A) Rabatak's genealogy
- (B) Gautamiputra's restriking of Nahapana's coins
- (C) Ai-Khanoum's theatre
- (D) Heliodorus' dedication

Answer: B - Gautamiputra's restriking of Nahapana's coins Named evidence/concept: Overstruck silver coins.

Explanation: Independent check on political displacement. **Qualification:** Does not map every campaign.

Hard MCQ 15

Question: Rudradaman's Junagadh inscription is dated to:

- (A) Maurya year 72
- (B) Gupta year 72
- (C) Shaka year 72, about 150-151 CE
- (D) Kanishka year 1 with certainty

Answer: C - Shaka year 72, about 150-151 CE Named evidence/concept: Dated Junagadh text.

Explanation: Strong chronological anchor. **Qualification:** Era founder remains separate debate.

Hard MCQ 16

Question: Junagadh is analytically powerful because it combines:

- (A) Only religious doctrine
- (B) Only a foreign travel report
- (C) Only coin metrology
- (D) Public works, genealogy, conquest, Sanskrit and prashasti

Answer: D - Public works, genealogy, conquest, Sanskrit and prashasti Named evidence/concept: Rudradaman inscription.

Explanation: Multi-dimensional evidence unit. **Qualification:** Eulogy exaggerates.

Hard MCQ 17

Question: Gondophares belongs to the:

- (A) Indo-Parthian/Pahlava political layer
- (B) Kushana royal house
- (C) Kardamaka line
- (D) Indo-Greek line

Answer: A - Indo-Parthian/Pahlava political layer Named evidence/concept: Coins and Takht-i-Bahi.

Explanation: Preserves dynastic distinction. **Qualification:** Territorial extent uncertain.

Hard MCQ 18

Question: The most cautious use of the St Thomas-Gondophares tradition is:

- (A) Official Roman inscription
- (B) Later tradition requiring independent corroboration
- (C) Contemporary court transcript
- (D) Proof of empire-wide conversion

Answer: B - Later tradition requiring independent corroboration Named evidence/concept: Christian tradition.

Explanation: May preserve memory. **Qualification:** Not contemporary proof.

Hard MCQ 19

Question: The Great Yuezhi movement is chiefly reconstructed through:

- (A) Junagadh only
- (B) Ashokan edicts alone
- (C) Chinese texts combined with Central Asian archaeology
- (D) Sangam anthologies

Answer: C - Chinese texts combined with Central Asian archaeology Named evidence/concept: Qian Hanshu/Hou Hanshu.

Explanation: Explains migration framework. **Qualification:** Ethnonyms are mediated.

Hard MCQ 20

Question: Guishuang was:

- (A) A Satavahana district
- (B) A Greek city
- (C) A Shaka era
- (D) One of the Great Yuezhi principalities that became Kushana

Answer: D - One of the Great Yuezhi principalities that became Kushana Named evidence/concept: Chinese and numismatic reconstruction.

Explanation: Explains Kushana formation. **Qualification:** Do not project empire backward.

Hard MCQ 21

Question: Kujula Kadphises is associated with:

- (A) Unifying the Kushana branch and expanding south of Hindu Kush
- (B) Composing Buddhacharita
- (C) Repairing Sudarshana lake
- (D) Defeating Strato III at Sagala

Answer: A - Unifying the Kushana branch and expanding south of Hindu Kush Named evidence/concept: Coins and Yuezhi sequence.

Explanation: Foundational ruler. **Qualification:** Date ranges vary.

Hard MCQ 22

Question: The Vima Takto/Saddashkana problem demonstrates:

- (A) A settled official genealogy
- (B) Disputed inscriptional reading and dynastic reconstruction
- (C) A Roman trade embargo
- (D) A Buddhist council decree

Answer: B - Disputed inscriptional reading and dynastic reconstruction Named evidence/concept: Rabatak and coin debate.

Explanation: Shows evidence revision. **Qualification:** Name remains contested.

Hard MCQ 23

Question: Vima Kadphises' coins are notable for:

- (A) Purely Greek legends with no adaptation
- (B) No royal portraits
- (C) Gold/bronze issues and syncretic Shiva-linked imagery
- (D) Only Buddhist symbols

Answer: C - Gold/bronze issues and syncretic Shiva-linked imagery Named evidence/concept: Vima coin types.

Explanation: Monetary and religious policy. **Qualification:** Image is not simple creed.

Hard MCQ 24

Question: Most scholars cited in the package date Kanishka's accession to:

- (A) About 185 BCE
- (B) Exactly 320 CE
- (C) Exactly 78 BCE
- (D) About 127 CE

Answer: D - About 127 CE Named evidence/concept: Yavanajataka-era reconstruction.

Explanation: Current conventional anchor. **Qualification:** Some scholars retain 78 CE.

Hard MCQ 25

Question: The safest statement on the Shaka era is:

- (A) It begins in 78 CE, but its founder and relation to Kanishka are debated
- (B) Kanishka certainly founded it
- (C) It is identical to Vikrama Samvat
- (D) It began with Menander

Answer: A - It begins in 78 CE, but its founder and relation to Kanishka are debated Named evidence/concept: Era scholarship.

Explanation: Prevents chronology error. **Qualification:** Alternative proposals remain.

Hard MCQ 26

Question: Rabatak is written in:

- (A) Prakrit in cuneiform
- (B) Bactrian language using Greek script
- (C) Sanskrit in Kharoshthi
- (D) Greek language in Brahmi

Answer: B - Bactrian language using Greek script Named evidence/concept: Rabatak inscription.

Explanation: Separates language from script. **Qualification:** Readings are specialist reconstructions.

Hard MCQ 27

Question: Rabatak is crucial for:

- (A) Mauryan dhamma
- (B) Sangam port geography
- (C) Kushana genealogy, royal ideology and an expansive city list
- (D) Satavahana matronymics

Answer: C - Kushana genealogy, royal ideology and an expansive city list Named evidence/concept: Kanishka's inscription.

Explanation: Links rulers and empire claims. **Qualification:** Whole-India claim is rhetorical.

Hard MCQ 28

Question: Which statement about Kanishka's council is safest?

- (A) Coins describe the council
- (B) A contemporary transcript fixes Kashmir beyond doubt
- (C) It founded all Buddhism
- (D) Later traditions connect him with a conclave, but location and details are disputed

Answer: D - Later traditions connect him with a conclave, but location and details are disputed Named evidence/concept: Buddhist traditions.

Explanation: Preserves patronage memory. **Qualification:** Not secure contemporary documentation.

Hard MCQ 29

Question: Kushana political geography is best modelled as:

- (A) A multi-centred network with direct and subordinate tiers
- (B) One capital and uniform districts everywhere
- (C) Only a Punjab kingdom
- (D) A purely maritime empire

Answer: A - A multi-centred network with direct and subordinate tiers Named evidence/concept: **Bactria-Purushapura-Mathura evidence.**

Explanation: Fits varied control. **Qualification:** Boundaries remain approximate.

Hard MCQ 30

Question: A Kushana coin found in Bengal proves:

- (A) A Kushana capital there
- (B) Contact or circulation, not automatically annexation
- (C) The coin was minted there
- (D) Direct taxation beyond doubt

Answer: B - Contact or circulation, not automatically annexation Named evidence/concept: **Distribution method.**

Explanation: Protects against map inflation. **Qualification:** Context may refine inference.

Hard MCQ 31

Question: Devaputra and related Kushana titles express:

- (A) Monastic ordination
- (B) Guild autonomy
- (C) A close royal-divine relationship and exalted sovereignty
- (D) Republican equality

Answer: C - A close royal-divine relationship and exalted sovereignty Named evidence/concept: **Titles and iconography.**

Explanation: Royal ideology. **Qualification:** Literal worship remains debated.

Hard MCQ 32

Question: The Mat devakula evidence proves most securely:

- (A) A Buddhist-only temple
- (B) The first stone temple in India
- (C) Universal worship of kings
- (D) Royal portraiture and a monumental shrine complex

Answer: D - Royal portraiture and a monumental shrine complex Named evidence/concept: **Mat inscriptions/statues.**

Explanation: Shows royal image politics. **Qualification:** Cult function unresolved.

Hard MCQ 33

Question: Kushana coin pantheons are best read as:

- (A) Imperial engagement with diverse religious constituencies
- (B) Proof of one syncretic popular religion
- (C) Random decoration without political meaning
- (D) Exclusive personal Buddhism

Answer: A - Imperial engagement with diverse religious constituencies Named evidence/concept: **Named deities on coins.**

Explanation: Explains plural policy. **Qualification:** Popular reception is unknown.

Hard MCQ 34

Question: The phrase 'Silk Road control' should mean:

- (A) Chinese political rule over India
- (B) Strategic participation in and revenue from route networks
- (C) No maritime trade
- (D) Exclusive ownership of one road

Answer: B - Strategic participation in and revenue from route networks Named evidence/concept: **Route positioning.**

Explanation: Links empire and exchange. **Qualification:** Traffic volume varied.

Hard MCQ 35

Question: Kushana gold coinage proves:

- (A) Universal peasant prosperity
- (B) Roman political control
- (C) High-value monetary capacity in selected circuits
- (D) End of barter

Answer: C - High-value monetary capacity in selected circuits Named evidence/concept: **Gold issues.**

Explanation: Economic and royal scale. **Qualification:** Distribution was unequal.

Hard MCQ 36

Question: The Huvishka-era Mathura guild inscription shows:

- (A) A royal land census
- (B) A Sasanian tax reform
- (C) A Greek theatre company
- (D) Permanent investment with guilds for religious-charitable purposes

Answer: D - Permanent investment with guilds for religious-charitable purposes Named evidence/concept: **Akshaya-nivi endowment.**

Explanation: Guild finance and welfare. **Qualification:** One record is not universal.

Hard MCQ 37

Question: Kanishka's religious policy is best summarised as:

- (A) Major Buddhist patronage within a wider plural royal pantheon
- (B) Exclusive Buddhist iconography
- (C) Hostility to Shiva
- (D) Abolition of Iranian cults

Answer: A - Major Buddhist patronage within a wider plural royal pantheon Named evidence/concept: Coins plus Buddhist monuments.

Explanation: Balanced evidence. **Qualification:** Personal belief cannot be fully recovered.

Hard MCQ 38

Question: Which Mahayana claim is unsafe?

- (A) Merchant-monastic networks mattered
- (B) Kanishka single-handedly founded Mahayana
- (C) Kanishka is remembered as a patron
- (D) Mahayana grew through longer doctrinal and social processes

Answer: B - Kanishka single-handedly founded Mahayana Named evidence/concept: Buddhist history.

Explanation: Avoids ruler-centred origin myth. **Qualification:** Traditions still value his patronage.

Hard MCQ 39

Question: Gandhara art is best defined as:

- (A) A Mathura copy
- (B) A Gupta-only school
- (C) A Buddhist programme in a layered Hellenised north-western idiom
- (D) Pure Greek art

Answer: C - A Buddhist programme in a layered Hellenised north-western idiom Named evidence/concept: Regional sculpture.

Explanation: Balances subject and form. **Qualification:** Phases and workshops vary.

Hard MCQ 40

Question: Greco-Bactrian elements in Gandhara are most visible in:

- (A) Kshatrappa tax titles
- (B) Mauryan dhamma formulas
- (C) Tamil-Brahmi graffiti
- (D) Body modelling, wavy hair and folded drapery

Answer: D - Body modelling, wavy hair and folded drapery Named evidence/concept: Formal art analysis.

Explanation: Answers 2019 demand. **Qualification:** Not proof of Greek artist ethnicity.

Hard MCQ 41

Question: Central Asian elements in Gandhara include especially:

- (A) Kushana patronage, frontier costume and transregional workshop context
- (B) Only Corinthian pillars
- (C) Only Pali canon texts
- (D) Only Gupta land grants

Answer: A - Kushana patronage, frontier costume and transregional workshop context Named evidence/concept: Patronage/context.

Explanation: Separates strand from Hellenism. **Qualification:** Central Asia was internally diverse.

Hard MCQ 42

Question: Mathura differs from Gandhara through:

- (A) No Buddha images
- (B) Red sandstone, older local idioms and broader surviving religious range
- (C) Pure Roman marble
- (D) Absence of royal portraiture

Answer: B - Red sandstone, older local idioms and broader surviving religious range Named evidence/concept: Mathura corpus.

Explanation: Strong comparison axis. **Qualification:** Interaction still occurred.

Hard MCQ 43

Question: The Buddha-image emergence debate supports:

- (A) Mahayana alone as sole cause
- (B) Total disappearance of symbols
- (C) Multiple centres and causes rather than a single Greek invention
- (D) A settled Gandhara priority

Answer: C - Multiple centres and causes rather than a single Greek invention Named evidence/concept: Gandhara-Mathura evidence.

Explanation: Rejects monocausality. **Qualification:** Precise priority remains debated.

Hard MCQ 44

Question: Which pairing is correct?

- (A) Heliodorus-Sanskrit in Kharoshthi
- (B) Junagadh-Greek in Brahmi
- (C) Milindapanho-official Prakrit edict
- (D) Rabatak-Bactrian in Greek script

Answer: D - Rabatak-Bactrian in Greek script Named evidence/concept: Script-language method.

Explanation: Tests precise source reading. **Qualification:** Translations remain scholarly.

Hard MCQ 45

Question: Rudradaman's Sanskrit inscription demonstrates:

- (A) Expansion of courtly Sanskrit while Prakrit continued
- (B) Kushana Bactrian policy
- (C) Immediate end of Prakrit
- (D) A Greek royal conversion

Answer: A - Expansion of courtly Sanskrit while Prakrit continued Named evidence/concept: Junagadh language.

Explanation: Language-order change. **Qualification:** Not instant replacement.

Hard MCQ 46

Question: The best evidence-supported knowledge-exchange claim is:

- (A) Greeks created all Indian science
- (B) Greek astral vocabulary and texts influenced Indian astronomy/astrology selectively
- (C) India received no external ideas
- (D) Kushanas invented Sanskrit

Answer: B - Greek astral vocabulary and texts influenced Indian astronomy/astrology selectively Named evidence/concept: Yavanajataka/technical terms.

Explanation: Specific transfer. **Qualification:** Direction and dating need precision.

Hard MCQ 47

Question: 'Indianisation' should be reframed as:

- (A) One-way cultural surrender
- (B) A purely biological process
- (C) Reciprocal adaptation, legitimation and synthesis
- (D) Complete disappearance of difference

Answer: C - Reciprocal adaptation, legitimation and synthesis Named evidence/concept: Cross-source synthesis.

Explanation: Captures agency on several sides. **Qualification:** Power remained unequal.

Hard MCQ 48

Question: The decline of Kushana power is linked most securely in the west to:

- (A) Chola naval conquest
- (B) Ashoka's dhamma
- (C) Alexander's invasion
- (D) Sasanian expansion and loss of western territories

Answer: D - Sasanian expansion and loss of western territories Named evidence/concept: Later Kushana context.

Explanation: External pressure with regional effect. **Qualification:** Not sole all-region cause.

Remedial MCQ 49

Question: Correct the chronology trap:

- (A) Shaka era 78 CE; Kanishka commonly c. 127 CE
- (B) Menander founded 78 CE
- (C) Vikrama and Shaka eras are identical
- (D) Kanishka 78 BCE

Answer: A - Shaka era 78 CE; Kanishka commonly c. 127 CE Named evidence/concept: Era separation.

Explanation: Repairs the most frequent error. **Qualification:** Older scholarship differs.

Remedial MCQ 50

Question: Correct the identity trap:

- (A) Milinda was Rudradaman
- (B) Nagasena is Milinda's interlocutor; Nagarjuna is different
- (C) Nagarjuna authored the transcript
- (D) Nagasena was Antialcidas

Answer: B - Nagasena is Milinda's interlocutor; Nagarjuna is different Named evidence/concept: Milindapanho.

Explanation: Direct PYQ repair. **Qualification:** Authorship remains literary history.

Remedial MCQ 51

Question: Correct the dynasty trap:

- (A) Both Kushana
- (B) Both Pahlava
- (C) Nahapana-Kshaharata; Rudradaman-Kardamaka
- (D) Nahapana-Kardamaka; Rudradaman-Kshaharata

Answer: C - Nahapana-Kshaharata; Rudradaman-Kardamaka Named evidence/concept: Western Kshatrapas.

Explanation: Separates branches. **Qualification:** Regional sequence remains bounded.

Remedial MCQ 52

Question: Correct the source trap:

- (A) Coins cannot identify rulers
- (B) Every coin marks annexation
- (C) Only texts matter
- (D) Coin distribution may show circulation without direct rule

Answer: D - Coin distribution may show circulation without direct rule Named evidence/concept: Numismatic method.

Explanation: Prevents inflated maps. **Qualification:** Context can strengthen political inference.

Remedial MCQ 53

Question: Correct the art trap:

- (A) Gandhara's Buddhist subjects used layered Hellenised forms
- (B) Gandhara was imported Greek pagan art
- (C) Greek art alone caused image worship
- (D) Mathura copied every Gandhara form

Answer: A - Gandhara's Buddhist subjects used layered Hellenised forms Named evidence/concept: Gandhara analysis.

Explanation: Restores local agency. **Qualification:** Workshops remain diverse.

Remedial MCQ 54

Question: Correct the Mathura trap:

- (A) Mathura had no Jain art
- (B) Mathura had indigenous red-sandstone workshops and plural patronage
- (C) Mathura used only grey schist
- (D) Mathura was outside Kushana power

Answer: B - Mathura had indigenous red-sandstone workshops and plural patronage Named evidence/concept: Mathura corpus.

Explanation: Restores regional distinction. **Qualification:** Interaction with Gandhara continued.

Remedial MCQ 55

Question: Correct the religion trap:

- (A) He banned Iranian gods
- (B) His coins were only Buddhist
- (C) Kanishka was a major Buddhist patron with plural coin imagery
- (D) He founded Buddhism

Answer: C - Kanishka was a major Buddhist patron with plural coin imagery Named evidence/concept: Coins and monuments.

Explanation: Balances patronage and policy. **Qualification:** Personal belief remains incomplete.

Remedial MCQ 56

Question: Correct the council trap:

- (A) Rabatak records the council
- (B) A contemporary transcript fixes Kashmir
- (C) No tradition exists
- (D) A Kanishka-linked conclave is traditional; location/details are disputed

Answer: D - A Kanishka-linked conclave is traditional; location/details are disputed Named evidence/concept: Source criticism.

Explanation: Separates tradition from inscription. **Qualification:** Patronage remains significant.

Remedial MCQ 57

Question: Correct the Pahlava trap:

- (A) Gondophares was Indo-Parthian, distinct from Shaka rulers
- (B) Gondophares was Kardamaka
- (C) All were Indo-Greeks
- (D) Pahlava means Kushana

Answer: A - Gondophares was Indo-Parthian, distinct from Shaka rulers Named evidence/concept: Dynastic terminology.

Explanation: Preserves sequence. **Qualification:** Texts sometimes pair Shaka-Pahlava.

Remedial MCQ 58

Question: Correct the trade trap:

- (A) One road was owned completely by Kanishka
- (B) Silk Roads were changing networks; Kushanas occupied strategic nodes
- (C) Only sea trade mattered
- (D) Roman coins prove colonies

Answer: B - Silk Roads were changing networks; Kushanas occupied strategic nodes Named evidence/concept: Trade method.

Explanation: Adds network and scale caution. **Qualification:** Volumes vary.

Remedial MCQ 59

Question: Correct the social trap:

- (A) Only kings participated
- (B) Manu's label is a census
- (C) Integration was reciprocal and regionally varied
- (D) Foreigners lost all prior forms instantly

Answer: C - Integration was reciprocal and regionally varied Named evidence/concept: Cultural synthesis.

Explanation: Adds actors and power. **Qualification:** Archive is elite-heavy.

Remedial MCQ 60

Question: Correct the decline trap:

- (A) One invasion ended all regions
- (B) Kushana fall ended Buddhism
- (C) Coins and art vanished immediately
- (D) Political fragmentation coexisted with cultural and commercial continuity

Answer: D - Political fragmentation coexisted with cultural and commercial continuity Named evidence/concept: Ended-persisted-transformed.

Explanation: Prevents dark-age narrative. **Qualification:** Regional timings differ.

PYQS AND ANSWER PRACTICE

PYQ 01 - 2019 GS-I Mains Q1: Gandhara elements

Status: Official printed question verified from the locally held UPSC Mains paper.

Question: Highlight the Central Asian and Greco-Bactrian elements in the Gandhara art. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model solution

Gandhara art was a Buddhist programme created in north-western workshops where Greco-Bactrian visual conventions met Central Asian political and social contexts. Greco-Bactrian/Hellenistic elements are visible in anatomically modelled bodies, wavy hair, naturalistic faces and heavy, pleated drapery; schist and later stucco supported this modelling. Central Asian elements operated especially through Kushana patronage, frontier costume such as tunics and boots, mobile artisans and the route environment linking Bactria, Gandhara and northern India. The Kanishka-associated reliquary from Shah-j-i-k-i-dheri and the wider Kushana monastic landscape show the patronage mechanism. Yet the subjects-Buddha, bodhisattvas, Jatakas and Buddhist ritual-remained rooted in Buddhist iconography, while Mathura provides an indigenous red-sandstone control. Gandhara was therefore layered Buddhist art in a Hellenised idiom, not imported Greek art.

Why this earns marks: It obeys 'highlight', separates the two named external strands, uses material and patronage evidence, identifies the Indian Buddhist core and adds a Mathura qualification.

PYQ 02 - 2020 Prelims GS-I Q22: Mahayana schools

Status: Official question verified locally; official key unavailable locally. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

Question: Statements: (1) Sthaviravadins belong to Mahayana Buddhism; (2) Lokottaravadin was an offshoot of Mahasanghika; (3) Deification of Buddha by Mahasanghikas fostered Mahayana. Which are correct?

- (A) 1 and 2 only
- (B) 2 and 3 only
- (C) 3 only
- (D) 1, 2 and 3

Answer: B

Model solution

Statement 1 is incorrect: Sthaviravada belongs to the early Buddhist school traditions and cannot be placed inside Mahayana. Statement 2 is correct: Lokottaravada developed within the Mahasanghika stream. Statement 3 is accepted in the question's doctrinal-history framing: Mahasanghika exaltation of the Buddha helped create an intellectual environment favourable to Mahayana. Hence 2 and 3 only.

Why this earns marks: It distinguishes early schools from later Mahayana and avoids making Kanishka the originator of Mahayana.

PYQ 03 - 2023 Prelims GS-I Q46: Milinda-panha attribution

Status: Official question verified locally; official key unavailable locally. INFERRED ANSWER - NOT OFFICIALLY VERIFIED.

Question: Pairs included Devichandragupta-Bilhana, Hammira-Mahakavya-Nayachandra Suri, Milinda-panha-Nagarjuna and Nitivakyamrita-Somadeva Suri. How many are correctly matched?

- (A) Only one
- (B) Only two
- (C) Only three
- (D) All four

Answer: B

Model solution

Devichandraguptam is associated with Vishakhadatta, so pair 1 is wrong. Hammira-Mahakavya is associated with Nayachandra Suri, so pair 2 is correct. Milinda-panha centres on the dialogue between Milinda and Nagasena, not authorship by Nagarjuna, so pair 3 is wrong. Nitivakyamrita is associated with Somadeva Suri, so pair 4 is correct. Two pairs are correct.

Why this earns marks: It catches the Nagasena-Nagarjuna trap and treats Milindapanho as dialogic Buddhist literature.

Mains 10M-1 - Distinguish the Central Asian polities

Question: Distinguish the Indo-Greeks, Shakas, Pahlavas and Kushanas in terms of origin, political form and evidence. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

Direct thesis: These were distinct but overlapping frontier polities, not one undifferentiated succession of foreigners.

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Indo-Greeks: Bactrian Greek lines south of Hindu Kush; portrait and bilingual coins identify rulers such as Menander. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Shakas: Scythian-origin branches at Taxila, Mathura and western India; kshatrapa titles and the Nahapana/Rudradaman record. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Pahlavas: Indo-Parthian layer centred on Gondophares, anchored by coins and Takht-i-Bahi. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Kushanas: Guishuang branch of Great Yuezhi, consolidated by Kujula and clarified by Rabatak. **Significance:** A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition. **Limit:** Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.

Balance/source criticism: Regional overlap and shared titles/coin conventions do not erase differences in origin or dynasty.

Reasoned conclusion: The correct historical unit is a connected frontier world with multiple political experiments.

Why this earns marks: It maintains directive fidelity, supplies 2-3 or more precise evidence units at the appropriate depth, interprets each unit, adds source/regional qualification and ends with a graded verdict.

Mains 10M-2 - Menander and the Milindapanho

Question: Assess the historical value and limitations of the Milindapanho for understanding Menander and Indo-Greek interaction. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

Direct thesis: The Milindapanho is indispensable for Buddhist intellectual memory but must be correlated with Menander's coins.

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The text identifies Milinda with a questioning king and structures Buddhist teaching through dialogue with Nagasena. **Significance:** The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence. **Limit:** Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Menander's extensive portrait/bilingual coin corpus independently anchors political authority and circulation. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** Sagala provides a plausible political-urban setting, while Plutarch preserves a separate posthumous memory. **Significance:** The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence. **Limit:** Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Genre and redaction mean the conversation cannot be read as a verbatim court transcript or full biography. **Significance:** The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence. **Limit:** Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.

Balance/source criticism: Literary construction does not make the text useless; it changes the historical questions it can answer.

Reasoned conclusion: Used with numismatics, it reveals the cultural afterlife of Indo-Greek kingship more securely than event detail.

Why this earns marks: It maintains directive fidelity, supplies 2-3 or more precise evidence units at the appropriate depth, interprets each unit, adds source/regional qualification and ends with a graded verdict.

Mains 10M-3 - Satrap system

Question: Explain the kshatrapa system and its political significance in post-Mauryan India. (10 marks, 150 words)

Model answer

Direct thesis: The kshatrapa system was a flexible form of delegated regional rule that enabled expansion but encouraged autonomy.

1. **Claim and named evidence:** The Iranian-derived title was adapted by Shaka rulers rather than copied as an unchanged institution. **Significance:** Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised. **Limit:** A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Rajuvula's progression from kshatrapa to mahakshatrapa shows office becoming sovereign status. **Significance:** Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised. **Limit:** A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Nahapana's varied titles and regional coin-inscription network reveal practical autonomy. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Kardamaka senior-junior rule under Chashtana, Jayadaman and Rudradaman displays dynastic co-rule. **Significance:** The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence. **Limit:** Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.

Balance/source criticism: Titles do not provide a complete administrative constitution, and practice varied by region.

Reasoned conclusion: Its significance lies in the trade-off between low-cost imperial reach and centrifugal regional power.

Why this earns marks: It maintains directive fidelity, supplies 2-3 or more precise evidence units at the appropriate depth, interprets each unit, adds source/regional qualification and ends with a graded verdict.

Mains 15M-1 - Kushana imperial structure

Question: Analyse the formation and structure of the Kushana Empire as a transregional polity. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

Direct thesis: Kushana power emerged through staged Yuezhi migration, Bactrian consolidation and a tiered network across Central and South Asia.

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Qian Hanshu/Hou Hanshu describe Yuezhi displacement; Khalchayan and Takht-e-Sangin support the Central Asian phase. **Significance:** The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence. **Limit:** Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Kujula Kadphises unified the Guishuang branch and issued coins south of the Hindu Kush. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Vima Kadphises' gold/bronze coinage marks expanded monetary and ideological capacity. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Rabatak supplies genealogy, Bactrian royal theology and an eastern city list, though its universal claim is rhetorical. **Significance:** A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition. **Limit:** Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Bactria, Purushapura and Mathura acted as major centres rather than a single capital hierarchy. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
6. **Claim and named evidence:** Kshatrapas and tribute-paying subordinates produced different tiers of control. **Significance:** Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised. **Limit:** A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.

Balance/source criticism: Coin finds at distant sites cannot independently establish annexation, and chronology after Kujula remains debated.

Reasoned conclusion: The empire's strength came from connecting nodes; the same delegated structure made regional fragmentation possible.

Why this earns marks: It maintains directive fidelity, supplies 4-6 or more precise evidence units at the appropriate depth, interprets each unit, adds source/regional qualification and ends with a graded verdict.

Mains 15M-2 - Coins and royal ideology

Question: How do Indo-Greek and Kushana coins illuminate political authority and cultural interaction? (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

Direct thesis: Coins were simultaneously money, royal portrait, multilingual proclamation and religious map.

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Indo-Greek portraits and ruler names make kings attributable unlike early punch-marked coins. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Greek-Kharoshthi/Brahmi legends adapted authority to different users and weight standards. **Significance:** The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence. **Limit:** Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.

3. **Claim and named evidence:** Agathocles' Balarama-Vasudeva type shows royal recognition of Indian cults within Greek engraving conventions. **Significance:** The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence. **Limit:** Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Vima's Shiva-linked types combine trident, bull and syncretic attributes. **Significance:** The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence. **Limit:** Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Kanishka/Huvishka types name Buddha, Shiva/Oesho, Nana, Mithra, Atash, Helios and Selene. **Significance:** The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence. **Limit:** Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
6. **Claim and named evidence:** Kushana titles and halo/flame imagery projected divine or divinely connected kingship. **Significance:** Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised. **Limit:** A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.

Balance/source criticism: A coin deity is not proof of personal conversion, and circulation does not equal direct rule.

Reasoned conclusion: Numismatics reveals negotiated sovereignty precisely when legend, image, metal and find-context are read together.

Why this earns marks: It maintains directive fidelity, supplies 4-6 or more precise evidence units at the appropriate depth, interprets each unit, adds source/regional qualification and ends with a graded verdict.

Mains 15M-3 - Gandhara and Mathura

Question: Compare Gandhara and Mathura as interacting but distinct centres of early historic sculpture. (15 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

Direct thesis: Both served Kushana-age devotional change, but differed in materials, workshop ancestry, visual idiom and religious range.

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Gandhara used schist/grey stone and stucco, with Hellenised anatomy, wavy hair and heavy drapery. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Its Buddhist programme included Buddha, bodhisattvas, life scenes and Hariti-Panchika under frontier patronage. **Significance:** Titulature and hierarchy expose how sovereignty, delegation and royal ideology were organised. **Limit:** A shared title is not a complete constitution, and actual powers varied by ruler, place and time.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Mathura used mottled red sandstone and drew on older yaksha and local workshop traditions. **Significance:** The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence. **Limit:** Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Mathura served Buddhist, Jaina, Vaishnava, Shaiva and royal patrons, including the Kanishka statue and Mat devakula. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Sanghol's Mathura-school sculptures show object/workshop circulation beyond the city. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
6. **Claim and named evidence:** Both centres participated in Buddha-image development, but priority and direct borrowing remain debated. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.

Balance/source criticism: Gandhara is not pure Greek art and Mathura is not an isolated, untouched indigenous essence.

Reasoned conclusion: Their comparison demonstrates parallel regional creativity within shared networks rather than a donor-copy relationship.

Why this earns marks: It maintains directive fidelity, supplies 4-6 or more precise evidence units at the appropriate depth, interprets each unit, adds source/regional qualification and ends with a graded verdict.

Mains 20M-1 - Central Asian contacts and transformation

Question: Central Asian contacts transformed post-Mauryan India far beyond the political sphere. Critically examine. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

Direct thesis: The transformation was substantial in coinage, networks, religion, art and kingship, but uneven and mediated by existing Indian institutions.

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Indo-Greek portrait/bilingual coinage improved ruler attribution and political communication. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Shaka kshatrapas adapted delegated government; Junagadh links public works, Sanskrit and regional legitimacy. **Significance:** A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition. **Limit:** Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Kushana Bactria-Purushapura-Mathura networks joined overland and Indian circuits without uniform control. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Kushana gold, western-Kshatrapa silver and guild endowments supported selected monetised urban sectors. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Heliodorus, Agathocles types and plural Kushana coins show religious adaptation across cults. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
6. **Claim and named evidence:** Kanishka patronage and merchant-monastic routes aided Buddhist transmission into Central Asia. **Significance:** The evidence connects political geography to institutions of exchange, mobility and patronage. **Limit:** The surviving record is urban and elite-heavy; scale and prosperity cannot be generalised to every region or household.
7. **Claim and named evidence:** Gandhara and Mathura demonstrate layered artistic innovation rather than simple import. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
8. **Claim and named evidence:** Greek astral vocabulary and multilingual inscriptions reveal selective knowledge and language exchange. **Significance:** A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition. **Limit:** Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.

Balance/source criticism: The archive is elite-heavy; rural life, lower social groups and regional non-participants are less visible, while conflict accompanied synthesis.

Reasoned conclusion: The period is best called reciprocal but unequal transformation, not foreign domination followed by passive absorption.

Why this earns marks: It maintains directive fidelity, supplies 5-8 or more precise evidence units at the appropriate depth, interprets each unit, adds source/regional qualification and ends with a graded verdict.

Mains 20M-2 - Kushana cosmopolitanism

Question: Evaluate the nature and limits of Kushana cosmopolitanism. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

Direct thesis: Kushana cosmopolitanism was an imperial strategy rooted in transregional geography, multilingual media and plural patronage, not a borderless social equality.

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Yuezhi-Bactrian origins and Chinese textual links place the dynasty inside wider Asian history. **Significance:** The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence. **Limit:** Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Rabatak's Bactrian-Greek script and Nana-centred royal theology join Iranian, Hellenistic and local idioms. **Significance:** A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition. **Limit:** Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Coins moved from Greek to Bactrian legends and displayed Indian, Iranian and Greek deities. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Purushapura and Mathura linked Buddhist, royal and urban patronage across distinct regions. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Silk-route and lower-Indus positioning connected caravan and maritime exchange. **Significance:** The evidence connects political geography to institutions of exchange, mobility and patronage. **Limit:** The surviving record is urban and elite-heavy; scale and prosperity cannot be generalised to every region or household.
6. **Claim and named evidence:** Buddhist missions and Gandhara imagery travelled toward Central and East Asia. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
7. **Claim and named evidence:** Mat and Surkh Kotal royal images created a transregional language of sacral kingship. **Significance:** The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence. **Limit:** Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
8. **Claim and named evidence:** Guild endowments and local cults show cosmopolitan rule operating through regional institutions. **Significance:** The evidence connects political geography to institutions of exchange, mobility and patronage. **Limit:** The surviving record is urban and elite-heavy; scale and prosperity cannot be generalised to every region or household.

Balance/source criticism: Direct rule was tiered, coin circulation uneven, and elite cultural plurality says little about equality or everyday bilingualism.

Reasoned conclusion: Cosmopolitanism describes connected repertoires and audiences; its political foundation remained conquest, hierarchy and selective access.

Why this earns marks: It maintains directive fidelity, supplies 5-8 or more precise evidence units at the appropriate depth, interprets each unit, adds source/regional qualification and ends with a graded verdict.

Mains 20M-3 - Source criticism and chronology

Question: Why are chronology and political geography of the Indo-Greeks, Shakas and Kushanas difficult to reconstruct? Discuss with sources. (20 marks, 250 words)

Model answer

Direct thesis: The difficulty arises from concurrent rulers, fragmented archives, mobile coinage, rhetorical inscriptions and later textual traditions.

1. **Claim and named evidence:** Dozens of Bactro-Indo-Greek rulers are known only from coins; monograms and sequences remain debated. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
2. **Claim and named evidence:** Overstrikes can mean conquest, succession or metal reuse, complicating political inference. **Significance:** Numismatic form, legend and metal make authority or exchange materially testable. **Limit:** Coin imagery does not automatically reveal personal belief, and circulation does not equal a political frontier.
3. **Claim and named evidence:** Milindapanho preserves intellectual memory rather than a continuous reign narrative. **Significance:** The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence. **Limit:** Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.
4. **Claim and named evidence:** Shaka branches at Taxila, Mathura and western India overlap and use repeated kshatrapa titles. **Significance:** Material, workshop and iconographic evidence identifies a regional practice and its patronage context. **Limit:** Style cannot identify an artist's ethnicity or settle priority, belief and political control by itself.
5. **Claim and named evidence:** Azes-Vikrama and Shaka-era founder debates reveal uncertain era identification. **Significance:** The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence. **Limit:** Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
6. **Claim and named evidence:** Rabatak clarifies Kushana genealogy but includes disputed readings and an exaggerated whole-India claim. **Significance:** A named and locatable inscription gives a stronger chronological or ideological anchor than a free-floating tradition. **Limit:** Epigraphs remain selective; prashasti, damaged readings and universalising claims require corroboration.
7. **Claim and named evidence:** Kanishka's accession is commonly c. 127 CE, while the older 78 CE view survives. **Significance:** The named unit anchors one required dimension of the answer in precise historical evidence. **Limit:** Its reach must remain bounded by date, region, source class and the uncertainty of reconstruction.
8. **Claim and named evidence:** Chinese and classical texts use external ethnonyms and may rely on distance or hearsay. **Significance:** The textual witness preserves intellectual memory, external chronology or a perspective missing from material evidence. **Limit:** Genre, redaction, translation, distance and authorial purpose limit literal event reconstruction.

Balance/source criticism: The archive is difficult, not unusable: convergence among dated inscriptions, die studies, archaeology and texts creates bounded conclusions.

Reasoned conclusion: A defensible reconstruction therefore uses ranges, regional maps and explicit confidence levels rather than false precision.

Why this earns marks: It maintains directive fidelity, supplies 5-8 or more precise evidence units at the appropriate depth, interprets each unit, adds source/regional qualification and ends with a graded verdict.